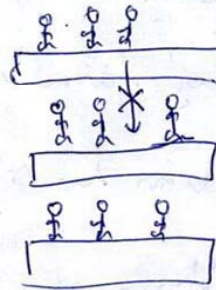


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(c) Critically analyse Functional Theory of Social Stratification. (15 marks)

Social stratification is the arrangement of social groups in a layered form that it is not possible to move from one strata to another strata. Only the strata as a whole move up or down.

Eg. Caste system



Functional theory: Functionalists like Emile Durkheim explain that as with all cultural traits even social stratification has a function. They explain that social stratification keeps the social order running smoothly.

Eg. Caste system from functionalist

perspective is described as 'functional discrimination' based on occupation.

(i) Functional theory merely concerns itself with functionality of the stratification.

(ii) It doesn't enquire into the question that whether social stratification is desirable or not?

(iii) Thus, functional theory doesn't answer the moral question of whether social stratification is ethical or not.

(iv) Functional theory also only explains the current stratification. It doesn't take into ~~the~~ account the social uncertainty that arises when the social structure changes from one to another.

(v) Thus, functional theory only explains the social equilibrium but not the intermediate uncertainty between two social equilibrium orders.

(vi) Due to attachment of function to stratification, functional theory is criticized to have justified discrimination.

Functionalists constrain themselves to explain the function but do not go into the moral code.

Thus, their theories come off as having justified discrimination.

However, they did not support stratification, only merely spelled out its function.